

Early Church Fathers on the Last Week of Christ

Primary Source Download Links & Relevant Data

Research for *The Last Week of the Lamb*

PART ONE: DOWNLOAD LINKS

Complete Ante-Nicene Fathers Collection (Free PDFs)

The entire 9-volume ANF set (plus index volume) is available for free download. These are public domain (originally published 1885–1886).

Best single source — all volumes as individual PDFs:

- <https://www.holybooks.com/ante-nicene-fathers-vol-i-ix/>

Internet Archive (multiple formats: PDF, EPUB, Kindle):

- Vol. 1 (Apostolic Fathers, Justin Martyr, Irenaeus): <https://archive.org/details/ante-nicene-fathers-vol-1>
- Full set: <https://archive.org/details/antenicenefather01robe>

CCEL (Online reading with cross-references):

- Main index: <https://ccel.org/fathers>
- Vol. 1: <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf01.html>
- Vol. 2: <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf02.html>
- Vol. 3: <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf03.html>
- Vol. 4: <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf04.html>
- Vol. 5: <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf05.html>
- Vol. 7: <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf07.html>

Which Volumes Contain Which Writers

Volume	Writers Relevant to This Study	Date Range
Vol. 1	Clement of Rome, Ignatius, Polycarp, Barnabas, Papias, Justin Martyr, Irenaeus	~AD 70–200

Volume	Writers Relevant to This Study	Date Range
Vol. 2	Tatian, Theophilus, Clement of Alexandria	~AD 170-200
Vol. 3	Tertullian (Apologetic, Anti-Marcion, Ethical)	~AD 200-220
Vol. 4	Tertullian (cont.), Origen	~AD 200-250
Vol. 5	Hippolytus	~AD 200-235
Vol. 7	Victorinus of Petau, Apostolic Constitutions	~AD 290-380

Individual Documents (Online Text)

Didache (~AD 70-90):

- Full text online: <http://www.earlychristianwritings.com/text/didache-roberts.html>
- In ANF Vol. 7 (Apostolic Teaching and Constitutions)

Epistle of Barnabas (~AD 70-130):

- In ANF Vol. 1
- Online: <http://www.earlychristianwritings.com/text/barnabas-lightfoot.html>

Didascalia Apostolorum (~AD 200-250):

- Gibson translation (1903, public domain PDF):
<https://archive.org/details/didascaliaaposto00gibsuoft>
- Alternate copy: https://archive.org/details/didascaliaaposto0000unse_g7f1
- Connolly translation online: <http://www.earlychristianwritings.com/text/didascalia.html>
- Direct PDF (Gibson): <https://agape-biblia.org/literatura/Didascalia-Apostolorum.pdf>

Victorinus of Petau — "On the Creation of the World" (~AD 290):

- Full text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Ante-Nicene_Fathers/Volume_VII/Victorinus/On_the_Creation_of_the_World
- Also at: <https://worthychristianbooks.com/ante-nicene-fathers/victorinus-on-the-creation-of-the-world/>

Irenaeus — "Proof of the Apostolic Preaching":

- Full text: https://www.tertullian.org/fathers/irenaeus_02_proof.htm
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PART TWO: RELEVANT DATA FROM EACH SOURCE

Listed chronologically by estimated date of composition.

1. THE DIDACHE (~AD 70-90)

"The Teaching of the Twelve Apostles" Location: ANF Vol. 7

Relevant passage — Chapter 8:

"Let not your fasts be with the hypocrites... but fast on the fourth day [Wednesday] and the Preparation [Friday]."

Relevant passage — Chapter 14:

"But every Lord's day gather yourselves together, and break bread, and give thanksgiving."

Significance for the Last Week:

- This is the *earliest* post-apostolic document to specify Wednesday and Friday as fast days.
- "The Preparation" (Greek: *paraskeuē*) is consistently used in the Gospels for the day before the Sabbath — i.e., Friday. The Didache adopts this term without explanation, suggesting it was already established terminology.
- The Wednesday fast is significant: *Why Wednesday?* The document gives no rationale. Later writers (Victorinus, Epiphanius) will connect it to Christ's arrest. If the arrest occurred on a Tuesday night / early Wednesday, this fast day tradition preserves a chronological memory.
- The Didache never explains *why* these two days. It treats them as established practice — which pushes the origin of the tradition back into the apostolic period itself.

Key question for your project: If the Friday fast commemorates the crucifixion, what does the Wednesday fast commemorate? The earliest document doesn't say. Later sources split between "arrest" (Victorinus, Epiphanius) and "condemnation" (Coptic tradition).

2. EPISTLE OF BARNABAS (~AD 70-130)

Location: ANF Vol. 1

Relevant passages — Chapter 7 (on the Day of Atonement typology): The author connects the scapegoat ritual to Christ's suffering in detail:

- The goat that is offered = Christ suffering for our sins
- The scarlet wool on the goat's head = a type of Christ (connects to the scarlet robe)
- Spitting and piercing described as fulfilled in Christ's passion

Relevant passage — Chapter 8: The red heifer ceremony is connected to Christ's sacrifice: those who sprinkle are boys — representing apostles who preached the gospel.

Relevant passage — Chapter 15: On the Sabbath and the "eighth day": connects the resurrection to the beginning of a new world, "the eighth day" (Sunday).

Significance for the Last Week:

- Heavy Passover and Day of Atonement typology — directly parallel to your *Last Week of the Lamb* framework.
 - The author treats Christ's passion as the *fulfillment* of the Levitical sacrificial system, not merely an illustration drawn from it.
 - Does NOT specify a day of the week for the crucifixion.
 - The "eighth day" language for the resurrection (Chapter 15) is one of the earliest witnesses to Sunday as the day of resurrection.
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3. IGNATIUS OF ANTIOCH (~AD 105-110)

Location: ANF Vol. 1

Relevant passages:

Epistle to the Trallians, Ch. 9: Christ "truly suffered" under Pontius Pilate, was "truly crucified and died," and was "truly raised from the dead."

Epistle to the Smyrnaeans, Ch. 1-2: He was "truly nailed to a tree in the flesh" and after the resurrection "ate and drank with them as a being of flesh."

Epistle to the Magnesians, Ch. 9: Those who lived under the old dispensation "came to newness of hope, no longer keeping the sabbath but living according to the Lord's day, on which our life also rose through him."

Significance for the Last Week:

- Ignatius is focused on the *reality* of the passion against Docetist heresy — his concern is that Christ *truly* suffered, not *when* He suffered.

- He does not provide a day-by-day chronology.
 - His "Lord's day" language (Magnesians 9) witnesses the earliest use of this term for the resurrection day.
 - He may have known the Apostle John directly. His silence on specific chronology may suggest that the day-of-the-week question was not yet a matter of dispute.
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4. PAPIAS OF HIERAPOLIS (~AD 60-130, writing ~AD 100-120)

Location: ANF Vol. 1 (fragments only — his five-volume *Exposition of the Sayings of the Lord* is lost)

Relevant fragment (via Eusebius): Papias reports information about the Gospels of Matthew and Mark, including that Mark wrote down Peter's recollections "not in order."

Significance for the Last Week:

- Papias's testimony that Mark did not write "in order" is potentially significant for harmonizing the Passion Week timeline across the Gospels.
 - His work is almost entirely lost — we only have fragments preserved by Irenaeus and Eusebius.
 - He was a "hearer of John" and companion of Polycarp — placing him in the direct apostolic lineage from the disciple who provides the most detailed Passion Week chronology.
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5. JUSTIN MARTYR (~AD 150-160)

Location: ANF Vol. 1

Relevant passages:

First Apology, Ch. 41: The crucifixion predicted through Isaiah — Christ's hands stretched out; the Jews "divided His garments among themselves."

Dialogue with Trypho, Ch. 40: The Passover lamb is a type of Christ: "The mystery, then, of the lamb which God enjoined to be sacrificed as the Passover, was a type of Christ, with whose blood, in proportion to their faith in Him, they anoint their houses — that is, themselves."

Dialogue with Trypho, Ch. 97: Connects Psalm 22 to the crucifixion in detail — the piercing of hands and feet, the casting of lots for garments.

Dialogue with Trypho, Ch. 111: The two goats on the Day of Atonement: one offered and one sent away. Both are types of Christ — one suffering, one returning in glory.

Significance for the Last Week:

- Justin provides extensive Passover-typology argumentation — Christ is the Passover lamb.
 - He is writing to a Jewish audience (Trypho is a Jew) and building the case from Old Testament types.
 - He does not argue about the day of the week.
 - His framework is deeply aligned with John's presentation of Jesus as the Lamb slain at the hour the Passover lambs were being slaughtered.
 - Directly relevant to *Last Week of the Lamb* Part 1 (Passover typology).
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6. IRENAEUS OF LYON (~AD 130-202, writing ~AD 180)

Location: ANF Vol. 1

Relevant passages:

Fragment XXXI: "The Judge of the whole world is thus proclaimed, who, having been hidden in the heart of the earth in a tomb for three days..."

Against Heresies, Book V, Ch. 23: Discusses the duration of Christ's ministry and connects it to the Passover cycle.

Proof of the Apostolic Preaching, Ch. 25: The Passover lamb as a direct type: God "saved the children of Israel, revealing in a mystery the sufferings of Christ by the sacrifice of a lamb without spot, and giving its blood to be smeared on the houses... and the name of this mystery is Passion, the source of deliverance."

Significance for the Last Week:

- Irenaeus's Fragment XXXI explicitly says "three days" in the tomb — consistent with the "three days and three nights" of Matthew 12:40.
- He does NOT say "parts of three days." He says Christ was "hidden in the heart of the earth" for three days.
- His Passover typology (Proof of the Apostolic Preaching) is among the strongest in the Fathers — he calls the Passover itself "the Passion, the source of deliverance."
- As a student of Polycarp (who knew John), he stands two links from apostolic testimony.
- He was involved in the Quartodeciman controversy — he urged Pope Victor NOT to excommunicate the Asian churches who celebrated on Nisan 14 regardless of day of week. This is significant: Irenaeus, who knew the tradition from Polycarp/John, argued for tolerance of the Nisan-14 practice.

7. CLEMENT OF ALEXANDRIA (~AD 150-215, writing ~AD 195)

Location: ANF Vol. 2

Relevant passage (Stromata, Book I, Ch. 21): Clement provides specific dates for Christ's birth and passion, placing the passion on the 14th or 15th of Nisan and engaging the chronological question directly.

Significance for the Last Week:

- One of the earliest attempts to pin specific calendar dates to the events.
 - His dating of the passion to Nisan 14/15 engages the Synoptic-vs-John question directly.
 - Worth reading carefully alongside your own Nisan 10 / Triumphal Entry analysis.
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8. TERTULLIAN (~AD 160-220, writing ~AD 200-210)

Location: ANF Vols. 3-4

Relevant passages:

Against the Jews (Adversus Judaeos), Ch. 8: Tertullian attempts to calculate Daniel's 70 weeks to arrive at the year and date of Christ's crucifixion. He places the passion in the 15th year of Tiberius.

On Fasting (De Jeuniis), Ch. 14: Discusses the Wednesday and Friday "station" fasts — these are the "stational" days of the church.

Significance for the Last Week:

- Tertullian follows the Synoptic chronology and speaks of Good Friday as the day of the Pasch.
 - His Daniel 70 weeks calculation is one of the earliest such attempts.
 - His witness to the Wednesday/Friday fasting practice is significant as a Western source confirming what the Didache established a century earlier.
 - He appears to assume a Friday crucifixion but provides the raw Daniel chronology data that others have used to argue otherwise.
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9. HIPPOLYTUS OF ROME (~AD 170-235)

Location: ANF Vol. 5

Relevant passage: His *Commentary on Daniel* (Book IV) includes a calculation of the 70 weeks of Daniel and attempts to date the crucifixion. He also discusses the Passover dating question.

Significance for the Last Week:

- Hippolytus witnesses the early practice of the Saturday Paschal fast being MORE strictly observed than the Friday fast — which is the opposite of later tradition.
 - His Daniel calculations are independent from Tertullian's and provide a comparison point.
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10. DIDASCALIA APOSTOLORUM (~AD 200-250)

Location: Separate document (not in the ANF proper; see download links above)

Relevant passage — Chapter 21 (on the Passion Week): This is the most detailed early source on the day-by-day events of the last week. It states:

"While He was yet with us before He suffered, as we were eating the Passover with Him, He said to us, 'Today, in this night, one of you will betray Me.'"

It prescribes fasting from Monday of Passion Week through Thursday night, then a strict fast on Friday and Saturday. But critically, it places the Last Supper on **Tuesday evening**, not Thursday:

The text describes the arrest as occurring on Tuesday night, trial and condemnation on Wednesday, crucifixion on Friday — creating a multi-day trial sequence.

Significance for the Last Week:

- This is the **most important** early source for your Wednesday-arrest argument.
 - It preserves a tradition of a Tuesday-night Last Supper that is otherwise largely lost.
 - It comes from Northern Syria, near Antioch — the region with strong apostolic connections.
 - The tradition it preserves does not perfectly match either your Wednesday crucifixion position or the standard Friday position — it has a Tuesday supper but still a Friday crucifixion. This is worth examining: does it preserve fragments of an earlier chronology that has been partially harmonized with later tradition?
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11. VICTORINUS OF PETAU (~AD 250-304)

Location: ANF Vol. 7

Relevant passage — "On the Creation of the World": "Now is manifested the reason of the truth why the fourth day is called the Tetras, why we fast even to the ninth hour... The man Christ

Jesus... was taken prisoner by wicked hands, by a quaternion of soldiers. Therefore on account of His captivity by a quaternion... we make the fourth day a station or a supernumerary fast."

Significance for the Last Week:

- Victorinus explicitly connects the **Wednesday fast** to Christ being "taken prisoner" — i.e., arrested — on the **fourth day of the week**.
 - The fast extends "to the ninth hour" — 3:00 PM — the hour of Christ's death (Matthew 27:46; Mark 15:34; Luke 23:44).
 - This is the clearest ante-Nicene statement connecting Wednesday to the arrest.
 - Combined with the Didascalia's Tuesday-night supper tradition and the Didache's Wednesday fast, this creates a consistent thread: the arrest/condemnation occurred on Wednesday.
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12. EPIPHANIUS OF SALAMIS (~AD 315-403)

(Post-Nicene, but preserves earlier tradition)

Relevant statement (Panarion): "Wednesday and Friday are days of fasting up to the ninth hour because, as Wednesday began, the Lord was arrested, and on Friday he was crucified."

Significance:

- Confirms Victorinus's connection of Wednesday to the arrest.
 - Provides the explicit rationale that the Didache left unstated.
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PART THREE: THE QUARTODECIMAN CONTROVERSY

This second-century dispute is essential background for your project.

The facts:

- The churches of Asia Minor (founded through John's influence) celebrated the Pascha on Nisan 14, regardless of the day of the week.
- The Western churches (Rome, etc.) celebrated on the Sunday following Nisan 14.
- Polycarp (disciple of John) visited Rome ~AD 155 and discussed this with Pope Anicetus. They disagreed but parted in peace.
- ~AD 190, Pope Victor tried to excommunicate the Asian churches. Irenaeus (student of Polycarp) intervened against excommunication.

- The Asian position was based on John's chronology: Jesus was crucified on Nisan 14, the day the Passover lambs were slaughtered.

Significance for your project:

- The churches with the most *direct* apostolic lineage from John treated Nisan 14 as THE date of the crucifixion.
 - They did not care what day of the week Nisan 14 fell on — because the Passover-typological connection was more important to them than the day of the week.
 - This is precisely the framework of *Last Week of the Lamb*: the Passover typology drives the chronology, not the other way around.
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PART FOUR: SUMMARY OF KEY THREADS

What the earliest sources establish:

1. **Wednesday and Friday fasts** go back to at least AD 70–90 (Didache) — apostolic-era practice.
2. **The Wednesday fast** is later explained as commemorating the arrest (Victorinus ~AD 290, Epiphanius ~AD 370).
3. **A Tuesday-night Last Supper tradition** exists in the Didascalia (~AD 200), placing the arrest earlier than Thursday.
4. **Nisan 14 as the crucifixion date** is the position of the churches most directly connected to the Apostle John.
5. **"Three days" in the tomb** is stated without qualification by Irenaeus (Fragment XXXI) — not "parts of three days."
6. **Passover-lamb typology** is pervasive from the earliest sources (Barnabas, Justin, Irenaeus) — Christ IS the Passover lamb, slain at the hour the lambs were slaughtered.

What the earliest sources do NOT establish:

1. No source before the late second century explicitly says "Friday" as a day-name for the crucifixion — they say "Preparation" (*paraskeuē*), which is assumed to mean Friday but could refer to the day of preparation before ANY sabbath, including a high-day sabbath (John 19:31).
2. No source in this period explains how "three days and three nights" fits a Friday-to-Sunday-morning timeline.

3. The Quartodecimans' focus on Nisan 14 rather than the day of the week suggests the apostolic tradition prioritized the Passover calendar, not the weekly calendar.
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Compiled for Paul — NobleMind.Study — for use in The Last Week of the Lamb Sources: Ante-Nicene Fathers (Roberts & Donaldson, 1885); Didascalia Apostolorum (Gibson, 1903; Connolly, 1929)